

COLD OPEN--BLACK

Women's voices, whispering- indecipherable words, echoing.

We hear one woman's voice clearly as it cuts through the others...

VASHTI

No.

Whispers stop. Silence.

INT. LONG REGAL CARPETED HALLWAY -QUEEN'S QUARTERS

A group of WOMEN stand outside an imposing wooden door whispering to one other. Two of them are in prayer. Concerned nervous energy. One knocks timidly and waits.

INT. QUEEN'S QUARTERS

A WOMAN, VASHTI(early 50s) sits looking into a vanity- a wide oval of hammered and burnished silver mounted on a heavy decorative stand, ornately worked with relief carvings. She is wearing the full regalia of a queen. Her eyes are red, bloodshot, and her expression is worn and tired. She is unmoved by the shuffling of the women outside as the shadows of their feet play in the light beneath the door.

INT. LONG REGAL CARPETED HALLWAY - QUEEN'S QUARTERS

The women stand and wait. A man HEGAI (40s, Eunuch, unusually tall, bald) approaches. He calmly ushers two of the women aside. He knocks more assuredly.

HEGAI

My Queen...

Angle on Queen Vashti as a key is heard inserted into the door, which then opens. The two make eye contact in the vanity. It is clear from Vashti's countenance that she is resolute. Her gaze stiff and unmoving. She looks at his reflection and Hegai nods almost imperceptibly. The women's voices raise in the hall.

HEGAI (CONT'D)

...They're coming.

On Vashti as we hear the voices of men in the distance and hurried footsteps approaching...close in on Vashti's stoic face...

BLACK

Beginning credits

Title Card- ESTHER

EXT. RURAL FARM -DAY

A small handheld sickle rushes through wheat. It is in the hand of... HADASSAH/ESTHER (early 20s – casting note: should bear a marked facial resemblance to Vashti). Working in the grain plot gathering grain, a basket resting on her hip. Alone, she is fluid and in her element.

She moves through the stalks and gathers a handful in one hand – pulling several together. Then with her other hand, she uses the sickle to cut low near the base of the stalk. She lays one cut bundle down and tucks another under her arm. When she has an armful, she binds it loosely and places it in the basket.

It's rhythmic and repetitive. Bend, gather, cut, bundle. Bend, gather, cut, bundle.

The grain is at roughly waist height. The stalks are dry and golden – they rustle and shift. The chaff gets on her clothes and skin. It's itchy, hot work.

Blowing wheat out of her eye and wiping her brow with the back of her hand, she looks out over the farm. She sees MORDECAI (40s) arriving home. He immediately tends to the sheep and the goats who linger by the house. He sees her and they exchange a wave. She continues to work.

After some time, she finishes cutting. She binds the last sheaf. She stacks it with the others. Small golden pyramids standing in the stubble of the cut field. She picks up her basket and sickle and walks back toward the house as the light of the day fades. The sheaves stand behind in the field waiting for tomorrow. She places her basket on a large earthenware vessel at the edge of a field and carries them both back.

EXT. ANIMAL PEN- DUSK

Mordecai works in the ANIMAL PEN beyond the garden. He uses a simple wooden handled scraper to shovel goat and sheep manure into another large earthenware vessel at the edge of the pen. She approaches and places the second vessel down next to him.

MORDECAI

Thank you, Hadassah. I started the fire in the Tabun... water will be boiling. How are we in the fields? Nearly there?

She nods.

HADASSAH

Ready for the threshing floor tomorrow.

Mordecai nods, pleased. Hadassah pauses outside the pen and cleans her hands using a cup and clay vessel. She continues on with the basket of grain and walks towards the vegetable garden next to the house. She approaches bean plants and examines them, handling two different types. Both are ripe. Hadassah calls out.

HADASSAH (CONT'D)

Mordecai- Fava or Lentil?
Tonight...

Mordecai continues to shovel not breaking movement and calls out.

MORDECAI

FAVA.

HADASSAH

(to herself)

Fava.

She gathers enough for the two of them, places them in her shirt (fashioned into a small basket) and leaves the grain basket and sickle in a small covered shed before the entrance of the house. She puts the beans on a nearby table and quickly begins shelling them. Mordecai approaches with a small pot and places it on the table next to her. It's goat cheese. He heads inside. Hadassah continues shelling.

INT. MORDECAI AND HADASSAH'S HOME

Mordecai emerges cleaned up as Hadassah finishes bread prep at a counter. They bring all the items to the table and start a ritual hand washing.

At a clay basin Mordecai pours water over his right hand, then his left. He runs through this twice.

MORDECAI

Baruch atah Adonai, Eloheinu melech
haolam, asher kidshanu b'mitzvotav
v'tzivanu al netilat yadayim.
*(Blessed are You, Lord our God, King of the
universe, who has sanctified us with His
commandments and commanded us concerning the
washing of the hands.)*

He hands the cup to Hadassah. She does the same.

HADASSAH

Baruch atah Adonai, Eloheinu melech
haolam, asher kidshanu b'mitzvotav
v'tzivanu al netilat yadayim.

They both sit. Hadassah drops her gaze and waits. Mordecai begins.

MORDECAI

Baruch atah Adonai, Eloheinu melech
haolam, hamotzi lechem min haaretz.
*(Blessed are You, Lord our God, King of the
universe, who brings forth bread from the earth.)*

They sit silently for a moment before serving food.

MORDECAI (CONT'D)

Today went by too quickly. I feel
like I was only able to do half of
what I needed to.

HADASSAH

Maybe you're expecting too much of
your day. Or of yourself. I had
just the right amount of day.

She takes a bite of food.

MORDECAI

(amused)
Did you?

Swallows.

HADASSAH

(serious)
I did.

MORDECAI

Well, tomorrow you can help me with mine. We'll have the threshing floor and some husbandry...

HADASSAH

What kind of husbandry?

MORDECAI

I know you don't like working with the animals since the hare...

HADASSAH

That was a long time ago.

Hadassah eats.

MORDECAI

You were sweet that first day you came... you wanted to set the hare free and when the fox got him... it was my fault really- his leg wasn't ready...

Mordecai, misty. Hadassah, stoic. She stops eating.

HADASSAH

Yes. I cried and you told me not to. Then explained the circle of life. Can you pass the goat cheese?

Mordecai absently passes the goat cheese. She puts a cover on it.

MORDECAI

I've softened since then, haven't I? Where does the time go?

HADASSAH

The time goes. I'll do whatever you need.

Hadassah stands to clear.

MORDECAI

It does. Tomorrow, after threshing...I saw an injured snake yesterday around the field- I'll find him and we'll have a new tenant. Not our typical guest but everyone needs care. Help me look for him. Then we'll go into town.

HADASSAH
That's fine.

As she cleans, her movements aren't fluid like in the field- they are stunted and jerky. Mordecai doesn't notice. He continues to eat. She continues her work.

EXT. HIGH GROUND- THRESHING FLOOR- MORNING

The threshing floor. A pale circle pressed into the earth - deliberate in a world that is otherwise organic. Men drive the oxen in slow circles. Women work the edges with baskets and brooms. The chaff rises and drifts.

A TODDLER sits nearby being babysat by AN OLDER CHILD.

Hadassah pauses watching the wind, when the breeze shifts she steps forward and drives the winnowing fork down into the pile of threshed grain- The rhythm finds itself quickly. Scoop, lift, throw.

EXT. THRESHING FLOOR EDGE- MIDDAY

Under the shade of a date palm, several of the women break for the day. Hadassah sits alone on a flat stone as a few others take their turn getting water from the clay vessel. They chat about married life.

WOMAN 1
He's enjoying his time with the teacher he says. I think he just likes getting out of the house...

WOMAN 2
Speaking of getting out of the house, Miriam's eldest, Naomi has been promised to Ezra's boy, Tobiah.

WOMAN 1
Oh that IS a favorable match.

Hadassah gets up for a second round of water.

WOMAN 2
Hadassah, has Mordecai found anyone for you yet?

WOMAN 1

Of course not, she's too helpful to him.

WOMAN 2

Don't let his causes keep you from your own life, Hadassah. The nerve of him making you wait so long...

Hadassah wipes some chaff from her eyes and offers the cup out.

HADASSAH

Did you get enough?

Woman 2 chuckles at Hadassah's deflection and Woman 1 accepts the cup.

WOMAN 2

Odd things afoot in the Persian court... I heard this morning at the market.

WOMAN 1

What did you hear?

WOMAN 2

Something about the queen being missing.

WOMAN 1

Missing?!

A child runs up and Woman 2 fills the cup. Makes the child drink. The child begins to run off with the cup and Woman 1 intercepts it and hands it back to Woman 2.

WOMAN 2

She hasn't been seen or heard from apparently for three weeks. Something about her throwing a ball at the same time the king threw a ball?...He didn't like it...

Hadassah listens.

WOMAN 1

Can you imagine?

WOMAN 2

I cannot.

WOMAN 1

And then something more about the king hosting a beauty pageant...

WOMAN 2

While she's missing? Waste no time...

WOMAN 1

Well, it's said they've been recruiting for TWO weeks...

WOMAN 2

Suspicious timeline...

WOMAN 1

Very. At any rate, the search is vast.

ANOTHER CHILD runs over and Woman 1 produces a kerchief and has the child blow their nose.

WOMAN 1 (CONT'D)

Hadassah, see how much fun this is? Get Mordecai to find you a good match already.

WOMAN 2

We can pull him aside and talk to him. You'll want a woman's help on this- Mordecai will be clueless about these things...

WOMAN 1

You'll end up with Reuben's nephew if we don't intervene...

The two women laugh. Hadassah looks back to the threshing floor. Their two husbands approach.

HADASSAH

Mm. I better get back to finish up.

Hadassah leaves and the two women giggle and corral their children into getting ready to leave. The men get water/pick up the children.

EXT. ROAD TO FARM/TOWN

Hadassah and Mordecai walk alongside their DONKEY. They get to a Y in the road and Hadassah veers right while Mordecai pivots to the left.

MORDECAI

Let's make the stop in town first.

Hadassah adjusts to follow Mordecai.

EXT. MARKET IN SUSA- LATE AFTERNOON

Hadassah and Mordecai make their way through the market. Where the threshing floor was only the Jewish community, the market is mixed cultures, Persian, Jewish, Elamites, Babylonians, Arabians, Ethiopians... The trade route brings an assortment of goods and services- from farm supply to jewelers. Mordecai continues walking, while Hadassah visits a Cushite vendor, AYANA (20s), they are the same age and share an immediately warm reunion.

AYANA

Hello, Esther! Come to see the fine wares today? Want to see what's new this week?

Esther smiles.

HADASSAH/ESTHER

Everything is so beautiful, Ayana.

Ayana opens a box and picks through.

AYANA

First, let me show you this...

She pulls out a small piece of iridescent fabric.

AYANA (CONT'D)

This is Netela with Tibeb gold metallic threading. It's Ethiopian- Near Cush, where I'm from. It's a scrap leftover from a robe we made. I saved it for you...

Esther's eyes widen.

ESTHER

No, you must use it!

AYANA

Don't be silly. It's much too small... It's for you!

Esther beams, turning the fabric over in the rays of the sun.

AYANA (CONT'D)

Now, necklaces. Lets try this one on you, shall we? It's my favorite right now...

The two giggle. Esther turns around obligingly and lifts her hair. Ayana places the elaborate necklace around Esther's neck as Esther looks into the bronze reflecting surface (note to production- mirror should be reminiscent enough of Vashti's mirror in cold open).

AYANA (CONT'D)

Fit for a queen.

EXT. MARKET IN SUSA- LATE AFTERNOON

Elsewhere, Mordecai is eyeing animal feed with a Jewish vendor, REUBEN.

REUBEN

What type of snake? I have some quail egg...

MORDECAI

Quail egg will do. Persian Ratsnake. I'll take enough for three days. That should heal him.

REUBEN

Ah, they're greedy, you'll want double that.

Reuben places 6 quail eggs into a small container and slides the box along the counter to Mordecai. Mordecai picks two out and leaves them on the counter.

REUBEN (CONT'D)

Haven't seen you for weeks, Mordecai.

MORDECAI

We've been in the fields...emerged today.

REUBEN

Right. Are you still hoarding away your pretty cousin? She ought to be beyond marrying age now, Mordecai...

MORDECAI

So I'm told.

Mordecai places money down.

REUBEN

I have a nephew she may be
interested in.

MORDECAI

I've seen your nephew, Reuben.
Thank you for the quail eggs.

REUBEN

Who's the snake now? You can't put
time off forever, Mordecai.

Mordecai waves Reuben off and continues through the market.
He overhears a discussion between TWO PERSIAN MEN.

MAN 1

The decree went out two weeks ago,
"A man should rule in his own
home"... had to come from the king
himself.

MAN 2

What do you think she did? The
queen. She must've done
something...

MAN 1

I don't know...I heard she wouldn't
come down when she was called...

MAN 2

That doesn't seem like enough to go
to all the trouble of a decree.
Though I guess...that's the whole
point of a queen isn't it... to
serve?

MAN 1

Mm.

He walks by another conversation.

PERSIAN MARKET WOMAN 1

Do they know what happened to her?

Persian woman 1 gives Persian woman 2 a long look.

Mordecai has moved off before the look lands.

He hears the next stall.

MIDDLE AGED BABYLONIAN MAN

A beauty pageant though? Certainly
beauty is in the eye of the
beholder?

OLD BABYLONIAN WOMAN

Youth is beauty to an old man like
that one and controlling the youth
make them feel powerful. Whoever
wins this pageant will represent
power.

The talk of the market swirls around Mordecai. Mordecai spots Hadassah across the alley. The necklace catches the light. She looks at ease in the finery. She and Ayana continue their conversation as Mordecai watches. Esther sees Mordecai. He waves and motions that he's ready. She and Ayana begin removing all the jewelry. Ayana kisses her on the cheek and Esther departs towards where the donkey is tied, towards the entrance of the market. He watches her go.

EXT. THE ROAD TO FARM/TOWN

Mordecai, Hadassah and donkey walk quietly back to the farm. Mordecai looks like he's about to say something and...doesn't. Hadassah sees it, carries on.

MORDECAI

Losing light. Find that snake
tomorrow.

Hadassah nods.

INT. MORDECAI AND HADASSAH'S HOME

By candlelight Mordecai sits and writes as Hadassah clears dinner. He pauses every now and again to look at her. She finishes and excuses herself to go outside. He watches her go. He taps his stylus, thinking.

EXT. GARDEN

Once outside Hadassah sits and looks up at the stars. From her pocket she pulls the Netela fabric from the market Ayana gave her.

Its gold shimmer shines brightly even in the evening light. Esther turns the fabric over in her hands. The night is quiet.

BLACK

Prelap

KNOCK KNOCK KNOCK KNOCK

EXT. DOOR TO A MODEST HOME- MORNING

A large gloved hand raps loudly on a weathered wooden door.

An OLDER MAN (60) opens the door, a YOUNG WOMAN (20s) behind him.

A PALACE OFFICIAL wearing the colors of the Persian empire stands at the door. Young woman backs up quietly. The man begins to shut the door when...

EXT. THE BACK OF A LARGE CART

The young woman has been tossed into the cart and a curtain is closed blocking her screaming face. Her parents cry mournfully off camera. Palace official marks his checklist then consults his copilot, PALACE OFFICIAL 2.

PALACE OFFICIAL 1
Any more in this neighborhood?

PALACE OFFICIAL 2
Next town.

Official 1 moves the carriage off scene as her mother comes into view from behind the carriage, collapses crying in the yard. Father has a bloodied nose and a black eye.

EXT. NEARBY HOME - MORNING

An OLDER WOMAN (70s) stands outside, shouts and waves her hands.

OLDER WOMAN
In! In! In!

She hurries two of the neighbor girls in. She sits the young women down on a wooden bench at a table. She pulls out a knife. One young girl sits still. The other flinches.

OLDER WOMAN (CONT'D)

Hold still.

She starts hacking at the first girls hair. She cuts a few pieces and a YOUNG MAN appears with BOYS CLOTHES.

INT. A SLIGHTLY WEALTHIER LOOKING HOME

TWO YOUNG WOMEN (27 and 18) are dressed in their finest dresses as their MOTHER brushes their hair.

MOTHER

It is a gift to have such beautiful daughters. This pageant is well timed to you both. We are so proud of you, you will represent us well.

Older girl looks nervous but hopeful. Younger, IRDABAMA is more quiet and withdrawn.

MOTHER (CONT'D)

We can walk the road to the palace and maybe along the way, we'll be seen and picked up. Escorted.

Older hopeful girl extends her hand as her mother fastens a bracelet.

EXT. ROAD TO PALACE- AFTERNOON

The Family walks along a quiet road, girls, mother and FATHER. After some time, two YOUNG BOYS riding donkeys pass the family. They are led by the OLDER WOMAN from the previous scene. They veer right, out of town with bags, as the family heads left towards the palace.

MOTHER

We'll just stay along the road to the palace... if we have to walk all the way there, we will.

The girls have their bags in tow and are fumbling lightly with the weight of them. The sound of horses behind them- the palace officials approach.

FATHER

This looks promising.

MOTHER

Yes! Excuse us! Hello!

Mother waves. The Palace officials spot the family.

OFFICIAL

Here we go...

The second official chuckles as they pull up to the family.

MOTHER

Hello! Yes... We heard the decree
of course, and are very pleased to
present our two lovely daughters...
for consideration for the pageant.
Both are very fair... as you can
see and highly skilled. Socially.

Both of the girls take the cue to curtsy.

OFFICIAL 2

I see this. Very well. Very
gracious of you and we will be
happy to accept.

Parents smile sheepishly. They bring the girls' bags towards
the back of the carriage. The officials climb down. The
girls head towards the front of the carriage, where they
assume they'll ride. Official 1 takes his horse crop and
slaps it up in front of older girl.

OFFICIAL 2 (CONT'D)

I don't think we'll have need of
this one.

Family's eyes widen. Mouths drop open.

OFFICIAL 2 (CONT'D)

Thank you tho.

Everyone unsettled, unsure how to proceed, Official 1 lifts
IRDABAMA's luggage away from father and takes it to the
front.

OFFICIAL 1

Better here where we can keep an
eye on it.

Official 2 takes Irdabama's hand and leads her to the back.
Off the family, more confusion.

OFFICIAL 2

M'Lady...

He offers her a boost and she stands momentarily unsure-looks back at family. They stand at the side of the road in a kind of dislocated paralysis. Older daughter chokes back a tear and waves. Family takes the cue from her and also waves. Irdabama gathers her courage, waves lightly, ducks her head and enters the carriage.

INT. BACK OF CARRIAGE

Irdabama is faced with her new reality. A cart of SEVEN YOUNG WOMEN ages 18-23, some disheveled and crying, a couple like her, dressed for some occasion that isn't this. Like her family outside, she's dumbfounded, mouth agape. The carriage begins to roll forward -she stumbles back.

EXT. ROAD TO PALACE-AERIAL SHOT

The carriage rolls on, covering the family at the side of the road in dust. Ahead at the palace, several more carriages arrive filled with just as many girls. They all move towards the busy palace gates.

EXT. MORDECAI AND HADASSAH'S HOME- GOLDEN HOUR

Late evening and Hadassah stands at the edge of the field. She is looking down at an injured PERSIAN RATSNAKE. Pity in her eyes, also a little disgust- Its back half is crushed. Mordecai deftly yet gently scoops the snake's body. He carries him to the edge of the shed by the field, where he's gathered materials for a nesting area- a clay pot, some grass and sand.

MORDECAI

Over here, old fellow.

Hadassah watches Mordecai situate the snake.

MORDECAI (CONT'D)

He'll be able to heal here. More ambitious than he should've been... ventured into the path after a rodent, I'd say.

Hadassah considers this and looks towards the edge of the field for signs of rodents.

MORDECAI (CONT'D)

Hadassah, there's something I want to talk to you about.

Hadassah takes a seat at the nearby table with the quail eggs from the market. She eyes them. Then looks back to Mordecai.

MORDECAI (CONT'D)
Something has come to my
attention...

Hadassah grimaces lightly.

HADASSAH
Is this about a match? I saw you
talking to Reuben... And the women
at the threshing floor said they'd
be speaking to you about a match...

MORDECAI
Ah, ...that's not quite, that's an
interesting coincidence but, no...

Hadassah folds her hands in her lap and waits.

MORDECAI (CONT'D)
It's come to my attention that
there's a pageant at the palace to
look for ...a new queen.

HADASSAH
New? The queen is missing... was
she found?

MORDECAI
Not exactly.

Hadassah contemplates this.

MORDECAI (CONT'D)
It accompanied a decree. Which
implied she was removed.

Hadassah shifts uncomfortably.

HADASSAH
She was removed...what was done
with her?

MORDECAI
(backpedaling)
We don't know exactly what
occurred. But we *do* know there's a
vacancy...

Hadassah balls a piece of her apron in her hands and shakes her head lightly. Mordecai grows more urgent.

MORDECAI (CONT'D)

...with access to real
opportunity... and the kingdom is
actively gathering women *your* age
as we speak.

Hadassah visibly tunes out and her eye is caught at the edge of the road where a small mouse now pops out of the dry blades of grass. As Mordecai speaks, Hadassah stands and walks to it. She cups it and picks it up. She brings it back and hands it to Mordecai who absently pets it while he's talking.

MORDECAI (CONT'D)

It's also clear to me it may be
time to see to it you're taken care
of beyond my abilities. I see it as
an opportunity. You have a great
beauty, Hadassah. I think this is
something you have the ability to
navigate to your advantage.

She takes the mouse back from him and holds it.

MORDECAI (CONT'D)

What you are able to accomplish
there for our community could be
something important. There would be
daily sacrifices, but...

He stammers.

MORDECAI (CONT'D)

You are a special child, you always
have been, I believe and have been
told you have the kind of beauty
that could go far... and be used
for good purposes!

He pauses.

MORDECAI (CONT'D)

I've made arrangements to take you
to the palace in the morning.

Hadassah holding the mouse in her hands, stands in front of him. Hadassah's eyes burn into Mordecai's. He averts her gaze. Once he returns her look, she holds it, then abruptly pivots on her heel and in a swift movement, bends down to the snake shelter and feeds the mouse to the snake. She stands and turns to face Mordecai.

MORDECAI (CONT'D)
(shocked)
Hadassah...

HADASSAH
He's been fed.

She's still. Faces him. Then pivots quickly and leaves. Mordecai is left to himself, what has just happened, and what he's organized.

BLACK

INT. MORDECAI AND HADASSAH'S HOME- EARLY AM

Hadassah wakes in the early am. It's still dark. She looks around her modest alcove bedroom. A burlap curtain separates her space from the main room. She looks out, sees Mordecai's sleeping mat has been rolled up. She hears a rustling outside and peeks through her small alcove curtain. It's Mordecai leaving. She drops the curtain and contemplates her next movements.

EXT. FARM- EARLY AM

Hadassah now dressed, walks through the still dark farm field where she's grown up. She runs her hands along the remaining grain and looks back to the house, the hills and beyond. As we pan to her face, she is saying a prayer softly.

ESTHER
Elohai, al tastir panecha mimeni
Sh'mor alai bamakom asher eilech
Hastireni v'al yad'u mi ani z'chor
oti.
(My God, do not hide your face from me Watch over
me in the place where I am going. Conceal me, and
let them not know who I am. Remember me.)

INT. MORDECAI AND HADASSAH'S HOME-MORNING

Hadassah has bundled her belongings and Mordecai enters.

MORDECAI

I ...have a horse and carriage I've
borrowed from Ezra. She's ready
outside.

Hadassah nods. She smoothes out her apron. Mordecai averts
his eyes.

EXT. ROAD TO PALACE

Hadassah and Mordecai ride quietly side by side. Hadassah
gazes at the fields and road she's lived her life traveling.
They come to the junction where the palace meets and veer
left. She turns to look back towards the road home. She looks
right towards town. After a time, she turns and looks
forward, saying nothing.

Mordecai takes this in. After some time:

MORDECAI

I have a connection at the king's
gate. He has need for some kind of
scribe and I'm going to talk to him
today about securing the role.

Hadassah doesn't respond.

MORDECAI (CONT'D)

It's as good as secured. He's an
old friend. It will put me there
most days.

Hadassah looks at Mordecai expectantly, tensely.

MORDECAI (CONT'D)

It'll mean Tobiah manages the farm.

The tension leaves her face and torso.

MORDECAI (CONT'D)

I'll be able to check on you daily.
I'll learn how to get messages to
you.

A pause.

MORDECAI (CONT'D)

Something you should consider...use
your Persian name there. Tell no
one who your people are.

Hadassah says nothing. She wraps her shawl tighter around her body.

EXT. PALACE GATES- LATE MORNING

Hadassah and Mordecai arrive at the bustling city gates. Persian officials close to the gates are there navigating new arrivals of girls. Mordecai looks to Hadassah who already has her bag off the carriage.

MORDECAI

I will get word to you.

Hadassah faces Mordecai, blankly. She turns and walks towards the palace gates. Mordecai takes a breath and a step as if to say more, stops. He watches her go until she is lost in the crowd.

EXT. CROWD AT PALACE GATES

A sea of people and in the center of it, Esther emerges. She slowly makes her way to the front. It is loud and dusty and chaotic. Her slow forward motion grounds the moment. She is just as dusty as her surroundings, chaff covers her cloak.

From here she sees PALACE OFFICIAL and shouts to him.

ESTHER

Excuse me, where do I go?

Another man sees her, HEGAI. He is elegantly dressed wearing the long elaborate headpiece of a Eunuch which adorns his bald head. Standing with parchment, he watches things unfold in the crowd.

PALACE OFFICIAL

We've got another contestant!!

Palace official laughs -another guard joins him. She looks around for someone to do something helpful.

PALACE OFFICIAL (CONT'D)

Over there!

Palace official points to Hegai. And makes a tall gesture and an even taller hat gesture. Esther doesn't have to look long.

The two meet eyes and Hegai quickly gestures to Esther to join the line of girls near him. She cuts through the crowd.

Hegai eyes Esther. Quickly drops his gaze. ADMATHA, at his side, says something unintelligible to Hegai who nods, glances back at Esther and turns, exits.

EXT. PALACE GATES - DAY - CONTINUOUS

Hegai moves through the chaos of intake, his parchments tucked under his arm. Unhurried. He parts the crowd without effort.

He reaches the gate. Nods to the guard and passes through.

INT. PALACE - OUTER CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS

The noise drops away behind him. Cool stone. Order. Hegai removes his hat, hands it to YOUNG EUNUCH ATTENDANT just inside the corridor. He walks along the interior of the palace. He is careful with his eye contact as he moves through the hall. He is deferential and drops his gaze with men of stature, meets the gaze of the women in employ who hustle by. He wears a floor length tunic- colorful, at his waist, a large brass key which clinks quietly at the fabric. His long robe flows lightly behind him. He arrives at a chamber door, knocks.

MEMUCAN

Come.

INT. MEMUCAN'S CHAMBER

Hegai enters MEMUCAN's (late 40s) chamber deferentially with lowered eyes.

HEGAI

M'Lord.

MEMUCAN

Hegai. Thank you for checking in.
How is everything proceeding? I
know you have some intakes at the
gate... but start at the search.

Memucan, seated at his desk, doesn't bother to look up from his papers.

HEGAI

M'Lord, at your request we've cast a wide net and have accessed the census and tax records from the 127 provinces across the region.

MEMUCAN

Very good. And provincial compliance? Have all the Governors responded?

HEGAI

Not all M'Lord...

MEMUCAN

Get me a list of those that are in violation. Include the Governors' names and locations. I have a meeting with General Tarshish and will advise him to activate my nearest stationed officials who will press the matter.

HEGAI

Yes, M'Lord.

Hegai makes note.

MEMUCAN

Of those who have responded- Which have come? And what are the outstanding dates of arrival for the rest?

HEGAI

It's still early M'Lord, the local carriages came in last week. The next round of arrivals are the Babylonians and some on foot arrivals, beyond that, Egypt at 8 weeks, India at 2-3 months, Ethiopia and Nubia at 3-4.

MEMUCAN

Mm.

Memucan writes some figures on paper.

MEMUCAN (CONT'D)

Hegai, how much inventory can we house?

HEGAI

M'Lord?

Memucan looks up from his figures.

MEMUCAN

How many women can we fit?

HEGAI

M'Lord, we plan to select 30.

He looks back down.

MEMUCAN

And these beginning acquisitions,
how many are there now?

Hegai looks at his parchment.

HEGAI

8. Once there are 10, I will
conduct the first orientation.

MEMUCAN

And, I should ask...

He looks up from his numbers again.

MEMUCAN (CONT'D)

How many of them so far are pretty,
Hegai?

Hegai remains stoic.

HEGAI

M'Lord, we have sent away 178 that
we felt didn't meet the
requirements. Under Lord Admatha's
careful advisement, which you
suggested. He's served his post as
my supervisor, most elegantly. He
has a refined palette.

MEMUCAN

Yes. Agreed. I'm so glad to hear
it's serving us well.

Memucan looks back down as he delivers...

MEMUCAN (CONT'D)

Don't send a eunuch to do a man's
work.

HEGAI

Yes, M'Lord.

Looks up.

MEMUCAN

Not a very practical question was it then? The pretty one. Quite right to keep me on task. You're Nubian aren't you, Hegai?

HEGAI

Cushite, M'Lord.

MEMUCAN

Mm. Known for their practicality and trustworthiness I'm told...

Hegai stands motionless. A beat.

MEMUCAN (CONT'D)

Yes. Very good, Hegai. Efficient and reliable as always. You may return to your post. Unless there's anything else of note?

He looks up.

HEGAI

No, M'Lord. Not at this juncture.

MEMUCAN

Very good. Dismissed.

INT. PALACE - OUTER CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS

Hegai bows and exits the room as quietly as he entered. As he walks back along the hall, he holds the brass key at his waist and a CARNELIAN PENDANT with carved imagery on a cord at his solar plexus- he tucks this away as his tunic momentarily shifted it to the surface. He gathers his hat from the attendant (who follows him out), exits back into the bustle of the palace gates, where his eyes land again on Esther who is now midway through the line.

EXT -PALACE GATES- DAY

Mordecai wanders the palace gates looking for his contact. He takes in the scene. It's not unlike the market in Susa with vendors and commerce, but there's a grittier more desperate feel. People have gathered here to plead cases and seek justice. Everyone pressing a point or working an angle. He passes a BLIND WOMAN begging for food and change.

BEGGAR WOMAN
Bread, sigloi, sheckel?

Mordecai pats his pockets and finds a date wrapped in cloth and puts it in her cup.

MORDECAI
It's a date.

Hearing his slight accent, she takes his hand in hers before he can take it away.

BEGGAR WOMAN
Baruch, Beni.

She pats his hand and lets go. Mordecai looks, making sure no one heard her- he also must hide who he is here. As he walks he takes in his surroundings- a flash behind his eyes- purpose suddenly in his step- Esther at the inside and he at the gate.

BAHRAM
MORDECAI!

Hearing his Hebrew name snaps him to. He looks around nervously with his breath held.

BAHRAM (CONT'D)
Marduk.

Relief, it's BAHRAM (late 30s) his fellow Hebrew friend who works at the gate.

BAHRAM (CONT'D)
Sorry my friend. Old habits...Here, you are Marduk. And I, Bahram. It's good to see you.

MORDECAI
Same my friend.

BAHRAM
Come. Let's move from this place.
Strange business on about the women in the palace, poor souls...

The joy of reuniting leaves Mordecai's eyes.

BAHRAM (CONT'D)
...we want no part of that foul mess...

Shifting gears.

BAHRAM (CONT'D)
Come! Let me tell you the work of a
petition clerk at the palace
gates...

Bahram slaps Marduk on the back and they move off.

EXT. BALCONY -WOMEN'S QUARTERS

THREE WOMEN (early 50s) ROSHNA and two others, stand on the balcony watching the intake procedures at the gates below.

ROSHNA
Just babies...all of them...

WOMAN 2
Not a coincidence.

They scan the crowds and take everything in.

WOMAN 3
We were that young. When we came.

ROSHNA
It's better now. Age...knowing.

WOMAN 2
She was still young...

ROSHNA
She was. And then ...she wasn't.

The three women pause- their friend is gone.

ROSHNA (CONT'D)
God help them all.

The two women turn and exit the balcony. Roshna stands a bit longer and takes in the crowd, her eyes land on Hegai. She watches him before she sees what he is seeing... Esther. Her gaze lingers for a moment and then her body stiffens. She grips the balcony and strains for a closer look. She turns abruptly and hurries inside.

EXT. PALACE GATES.

Esther looks at the girls she is surrounded by. They are younger than she is. Esther watches the interaction ahead of her.

There is a long table with parchments that Admatha sits at while Hegai stands next to him. Admatha speaks to a young woman. He doesn't look up.

ADMATHA

Name? Age? Region from which you hail?

YOUNG WOMAN

Atossa. 17. From Anshan.

ADMATHA

Speak up, girl, I can't hear you.

YOUNG WOMAN

(more loudly. barely)

Atossa. 17. From Anshan.

ADMATHA

Anshan, your family must be farmers.

The girl nods. She is vulnerable looking and quiet. She looks as if it's the first time she's left the farm.

ADMATHA (CONT'D)

And Atossa, a fine Persian name.

YOUNG WOMAN

Thank you M'Lord, it was my aunt's name. She was a kind woman.

ADMATHA

How nice. And... 17...Really?

YOUNG WOMAN

(confused)

M'Lord?

Leans in.

ADMATHA

(flirts)

Are you really 17? You look... younger...

YOUNG WOMAN

(laughs uncomfortably)

Yes, M'Lord. I just had a birthday. I...I'm really pleased to be here.

Back to a loud jolly register.

ADMATHA

Well then, congratulations are in order!

He pauses as he looks back at his papers.

ADMATHA (CONT'D)

Well, Atossa from Anshan, I think you'll do very well here.

Admatha maintains eye contact with her and hands her parchments to Hegai. Hegai accepts her paperwork and watches Atossa as she moves forward thru the line. She has a slight limp.

HEGAI

M'Lord, Unfortunately this young lady won't meet the requirements of the position. An extended amount of dancing will be required, I'm afraid.

Atossa's eyes go momentarily wide. Admatha hurriedly gestures to Atossa to walk a little, which she does.

ADMATHA

(irritated and covering)
So it is, my apologies. Next please.

Atossa, crestfallen is shuffled off by YOUNG EUNUCH ATTENDANT. Hegai reorganizes his papers and once again catches the eye of Esther. Who now makes her way to Admatha.

ADMATHA (CONT'D)

Well, what do we have here... Name, age, region...

Admatha looks up at Esther. And is quiet for a moment. And addresses Hegai.

ADMATHA (CONT'D)

Hegai, how many more in line today?

HEGAI

12. That I see.

ADMATHA

Noted. Again, name, age, region...try not to delay the process...

ESTHER

Esther, 24, Susa...

ADMATHA

A bit on the older side. One moment.

Admatha stands and turns his back to Esther and addresses Hegai.

ADMATHA (CONT'D)

Am I right in thinking she looks quite a bit like...

A long pause and Hegai waits a beat...

HEGAI

I'm sorry, M'Lord, I'm not sure who you're referring to.

Admatha annoyed. Stomps lightly.

ADMATHA

You know...

A pause from Hegai. And then an acknowledgement.

HEGAI

Ah, I catch your meaning, M'Lord. I'm afraid I don't see it.

ADMATHA

Then you're blind.

Admatha laughs and glances back at Esther. Leans back to Hegai.

ADMATHA (CONT'D)

She is quite something tho...

Hegai makes no comment.

ADMATHA (CONT'D)

And it might be amusing to see Xerxes sweat. Let's proceed with her shall we?

HEGAI

Very well, M'Lord.

Admatha takes a seat and Hegai watches the exchange between Admatha and Esther unfold.

ADMATHA

You were saying your age. Why are you not married?

ESTHER

I have been prioritizing the farm
and the needs of my cousin.

ADMATHA

Your cousin?

ESTHER

Yes, M'Lord.

Esther tries to meet his gaze, he does not return it.

ADMATHA

And why is this?

He applies pressure.

ESTHER

He raised me, M'Lord.

ADMATHA

An orphan?!

He looks up. Admatha warms to the idea of a vulnerability.

ADMATHA (CONT'D)

I see. Oh how sad. Well, we don't
discriminate and I'm sure you'd be
exceedingly appreciative of a
family experience. Very good. Hegai
will see to it that you have what
you need to flourish. Hegai?

Admatha hands her paperwork to Hegai and once she can no
longer see him, he watches her leave. He reverts to his work.

ADMATHA (CONT'D)

Next!

Admatha moves on. Esther and Hegai meet eyes briefly. From
behind Hegai the palace gates open and Roshna steps out.
Esther sees her. Hegai's gaze follows Esther's. Roshna meets
his eyes, then looks to Esther, then back to Hegai –
something of disbelief. He nods, almost imperceptibly. Hegai
motions to ATTENDANT to take his position.

HEGAI

M'Lord, please allow me to bring
this group of four into the palace
as well as deliver a list to Lord
Memucan. My attendant is well
trained and will be of absolute
service.

ADMATHA

Very well.

HEGAI

Please, follow me. Let me show you
to your quarters.

Hegai gestures to the group of young women to follow.

Roshna steps behind Hegai, in front of the group.

INT. HALLWAY MAIN COURT

Hegai leads them through the corridor. Roshna's presence sets the pace. One girl starts to rush ahead and Roshna adjusts, Esther sensing it, corrects. The group falls in line. Roshna walks just behind Hegai. Close enough to speak, but doesn't. They turn a corner and climb stairs.

INT. WOMEN'S QUARTERS

Hegai opens a large carved door to a vast room with curtains elegantly tied back framing what appears to be a large scale bedroom with multiple bed mats. At the back of each mat, a wooden chest. The girls step in and look around.

HEGAI

Welcome to the sleeping quarters
for the First House of Women.
Please select an unoccupied mat.
You may deposit belongings in the
chest behind your mat. We will meet
in the adjacent chambers (gestures
left) shortly. Please take only as
much time as you need to drop your
items, visit the washing room-
(gestures right)- and rejoin me.
There, I will run through what you
can expect in your first days here
and the days to follow.

Hegai excuses himself to the chamber as the girls begin to circle the room.

Here the four girls start to reveal who they are. PARI,
AMYTIS, NAILAH, and Esther.

Nailah, finely dressed and wide eyed about the scale of the room, leaves her bags by the door, and looks around.

Amytis, well outfitted, though more functionally, is unimpressed with the space and walks straight to a mat furthest from the door and the window, something away from noise and places her things down on the bed. Esther watches the other girls. Pari, modestly dressed, with a single shoulder bag, approaches the window.

PARI

It's an interior view of the courtyard. You can't see these quarters from the streets. Ah! It's the King's garden below, see?

Nailah stops taking in the interior space and joins Pari at the window.

NAILAH

Ah yes, the scale of the garden and these quarters is impressive! Though drafty...

PARI

My family lives here. So I've been by the palace many times but never inside.

NAILAH

Where is everyone from? What are your names? I'm Nailah- I'm from the Susiana Plain along the Dez River. My family are merchants. I grew up with the palace on the horizon... but like Pari- this is my first time here. Babylonian.

PARI

Pari...and from here, I said, Persian.

Esther sees that the last unnamed woman aside from herself is preoccupied with unpacking. She speaks up.

ESTHER

I am Esther. I grew up on a grain plot in Susa. What about you?

Esther deflects from her heritage over to Amytis. Amytis having already unpacked her bag is setting up a candle in a candle holder on her wooden chest.

AMYTIS

Amytis. My family is in the city. We should all think about unpacking and getting this over with.

Amytis stands and heads to the washing room. Pari and Nailah exchange glances. Esther clocks this.

Esther selects a bed and the other two girls follow suit.

Nailah retrieving her multiple bags from the door and Pari bringing her single bag to her bed. Esther kneels on her reed mat and opens her chest. Here she places a few clothing items. From a small side pocket she produces a couple GRAINS OF WHEAT and from her belt she pulls the Netela fabric from Ayana. Esther closes the lid.

CUT TO:

INT. CHAMBER

Hegai stands in front of a room of 10 young women. Roshna sits quietly to the side. Amongst the 10 girls we recognize IRDABAMA whose family was abandoned on the road.

HEGAI

Please allow me to properly welcome you. What has brought you is an unprecedented event. My task is to see that you are informed and that your time here is ordered. I am Hegai, I keep the house of women and this gathering falls under my authority. For matters that do not require my direct attention...

He gestures to the attendant behind him.

HEGAI (CONT'D)

...you may see my attendant first. SHOULD you require my oversight, you will seek me out directly. You are the first arrivals. We anticipate many more with the acceptance of few. Some of you will be dismissed. 30 in total will permanently move into the second house of women or other houses.

Hegai pauses to look over the crowd. He continues.

HEGAI (CONT'D)

Under my tutelage You will be educated on the structures and expectations of the palace and under the guidance of a select number of the second house of women, you will be led in some of the more daily duties. If you are literate I do suggest keeping notes for review.

His gaze falls on Esther before moving on.

HEGAI (CONT'D)

You will undergo a period of preparation. It will not be brief. You will be well attended during this time. Then the court will have requirements of you of which you will be advised.

Here he looks towards Roshna.

HEGAI (CONT'D)

You will find support in the elders accordingly.

He turns to his attendant and nods.

HEGAI (CONT'D)

Any further questions will be directed to my attendant. That will be all.

Hegai nods and exits. Roshna follows him. The young women look around at each other and an unease is exchanged. The young eunuch steps forward.

EUNUCH ATTENDANT

Are there any questions?

He waits.

EXT. ARCHERY RANGE- DAY

An arrow hits the edge of a target and sticks a landing. Memucan tsks, annoyed with himself. A lane over, Tarshish hits his second bullseye. Memucan looks irritated.

TARSHISH

Your priority is paperwork now...
don't be hard on yourself, Memucan.

Memucan reloads without comment. Tarshish chuckles at the lack of response. Memucan's second shot fares better. He immediately loads a third and hits his mark.

TARSHISH (CONT'D)

Sensitive rose.

Memucan packs up his quivers.

MEMUCAN

Come, let's have a refreshment. A
walk...

Tarshish gestures to AN ATTENDANT to pack up after them as both men walk the archery range along a path. Memucan keeps one quiver with him.

CONTINUOUS

MEMUCAN

Tarshish, what reports do you have
for me from the field?

TARSHISH

Rumblings of discontent from two of
the king's chamberlains...

MEMUCAN

The chamberlains are always
rumbling...

TARSHISH

Indeed. ...And I'm sure it's
nothing of note.

Memucan carrying a single quiver pokes at a leaf on the ground.

MEMUCAN

Anything at the gate?

TARSHISH

...some shifting of positions...a
commissioner - Haman - has been in
the king's favor recently...

Memucan plucks the leaf off of his quiver.

MEMUCAN

(absently)

Mm..

TARSHISH

...promotions, demotions... nothing outrageous.

MEMUCAN

Good. We need it relatively quiet there to continue to welcome the women...

TARSHISH

How is that progressing?

MEMUCAN

The "pageant" angle has drawn a variety of sorts...

TARSHISH

I'm sure.

MEMUCAN

Quite different though than you'd imagine...a few elements of refinery amongst the yokels. And as Admatha would have me assured...a few yokels for good measure...

Tarshish, knowing Admatha, nods. Memucan, serious now. Faces Tarshish.

MEMUCAN (CONT'D)

I have some unruly governors in the furthest provinces. They'll require some persuasion to turn over their maidens. I'd like you to oversee your men in these regions to see it's done well. It will involve travel. I have a list of the townships and the locations of their governors for you. Please remind them that these decrees are not only irreversible but ...wholeheartedly enforced.

TARSHISH

It will be done.

MEMUCAN

Good. Let's drink.

The men walk away. Memucan poking leaves with his quiver, Tarshish with his hands casually at his back.

INT. GATEHOUSE

The gatehouse. Massive columns. The ceiling impossibly high. Among the suppliants and petitioners waiting for an appointment with the monarch, Mordecai and Bahram sit at a small station in the chaos. Messengers darting throughout the space. Mordecai and Bahram, suddenly small men dwarfed by tall columns. Mordecai is standing behind Bahram who is furiously trying to capture what AN OLDER DISGRUNTLED WOMAN is saying to him. He presses a reed stylus onto a clay tablet.

BAHRAM

I may need you to slow down ...so
the goat ate your curtains...

DISGRUNTLED WOMAN

He eats everything! I can't get him
out of my kitchen curtains, my bean
plants, my chicken feed, my gates,
my...

BAHRAM

Got it. So and do you know the
neighbor the goat belongs to?

The woman points to someone several people back who shouts up ahead.

DISGRUNTLED MAN

I sold that goat, she's making
things up! I've got a few
complaints about her!

BAHRAM

Ok, have we got everything you'd
like to report?

DISGRUNTLED WOMAN

NO!

BAHRAM

I'm afraid we have reached our time
for this particular issue, but if
you'd like to file an extension as
it relates to the loss of an
interior home item vs something in
the yard, you can see my colleague
down the way.

Gestures down the table.

DISGRUNTLED WOMAN

Fine.

Disgruntled woman shuffles down.

BAHRAM

(to Mordecai)

And this is the life of a petition clerk. Overall you will hear and log; who comes, what they need, where they leave it, any resolutions or extensions filed, any other people involved- the full spectrum of human suffering at the convenience of our empire's front door. How does that sound?

MORDECAI

Great, actually.

Bahram laughs.

BAHRAM

You are a rare breed, my friend.

Mordecai looks pleased and strangely at ease in this chaos. Entertained.

CONTINUOUS

Off Mordecai's light smile we catch a reddish haired man we'll come to know as HAMAN (40s) finely dressed. Making his way to his post as Royal Commissioner at the Gate. He is stopped by an ASSISTANT.

ASSISTANT

Commissioner Haman, a word?

HAMAN

(gruff)

Yes, what is it?

ASSISTANT

If you'll follow me, M'Lord...

Haman looking irritated follows in the direction of the assistant

HAMAN

I've told you numerous times not to address me while I'm not at my desk...

Haman follows the assistant out. Rack focus back to Mordecai settling in.

INT. SECOND WOMEN'S QUARTERS- COLUMNED SITTING ROOM

A windowless columned sitting room, intimate in scale. Stone floor channeled for water – quiet, constant, feeding a small central basin. Glazed brick catching lamplight: deep blues, greens, gold. Draped fabric softening the walls. Bolsters and floor pillows surrounding the water feature. Beautiful, enclosed, and private.

Roshna paces. Not urgently, a slow thinking speed. The other two women sit.

WOMAN 1

How many were there so far, Roshna?

ROSHNA

10.

WOMAN 2

It's only been a few weeks and they already have 10 girls as replacement...

ROSHNA

Mm. Most of them look quite vulnerable... inexperienced.

WOMAN 2

Of course that's how they prefer them. Too new to know how they lie...

Do you remember when Xerxes had the secret concubines sent, not even the palace ones, and after she'd learned- he told her he "didn't feel libidinous when she was angry with him?"...

WOMAN 1

As if her reaction to his behavior was the failure... She endured him even then.

WOMAN 2

She loved him and this is what he did to her and for what? He destroyed the one person in his sphere who wasn't a sycophant...used her up. And he...

She breaks. Mixed reactions of sorrow, contempt, and anger from the women while Roshna chews on sharing more.

WOMAN 1

They don't want love. They don't want intimacy. They just want their emptiness to be filled. And it never will be.

Woman 1 notices Roshna's preoccupation.

WOMAN 1 (CONT'D)

Roshna, I see your mind moving. What has you? It doesn't look like grief.

Caught, Roshna considers the best way to begin.

ROSHNA

There is one amongst the new girls, also quite young, maybe older than the others...she looks like ...her.

WOMAN 1

What do you mean?

She sits down, comes clean.

ROSHNA

She looks very much like Vashti when we arrived together. She has a different interior...Vashti was always very forgiving and soft-this girl... her look will call attention to her.

WOMAN 2

How closely does she resemble her?

Roshna nods. The women contemplate this.

ROSHNA

We will have to watch them. All of them. And...look for the leaders amongst them. Help them support the weaker ones. Help them keep their souls. They are who we were.

WOMAN 1

They take and they take. They never stop taking. And then they grow weary of themselves in the taking. Because they know it's wrong. They'll just keep delivering newer and younger girls and then... shipping them out once they've drained them. Drained them.

Silence.

ROSHNA

I miss her. She was my joy. She was joy in this ...place. And he knew it. He knew.

INT. WOMEN'S QUARTERS

Esther lays quietly on her mat, in her hand she holds the Netela, turning it over. She gazes into the middle distance and lets her hand fall to her chest. A key turns in the door. It opens. Hegai enters.

A quiet evening in the young women's quarters - 10 girls in various stages of landing, taking in day one, getting ready for rest. Esther sits up.

HEGAI

Good evening. You will benefit from an early retirement. The morning will be a prompt start. There will be training, followed by an introduction to the house of women. Some of the elders have volunteered to be of service. This will be the start of quite the series of preparations.

He assesses the room.

HEGAI (CONT'D)

I trust you all have what you need
to be comfortable?

His eyes land on Esther's for a moment. She nods. His gaze is off, he exits.

AMYTIS

He gives me the creeps.

Amytis exits to the washing room. Some of the other girls look around at each other.

NAILAH

He doesn't need to give us the
creeps. He's a Eunuch.

GIRL 3

I don't think it works like that.

NAILAH

No, it does, if he came here young
he...

GIRL 3

I'm talking about feelings. The
feeling doesn't work like that. It
doesn't just go away with
information.

NAILAH

Oh. It helps me...

GIRL 3

It's disrespectful language...

NAILAH

Is it disrespectful to discuss?

GIRL 3

Women don't speak of these things!

IRDABAMA

Do they?

Eyes glance around the room. The girls don't know what women discuss. Esther puts her fabric away.

PARI
How does everyone feel?

IRDABAMA
I'm scared.

The girls look around at each other. One of them comes to her and holds her hand. Another pipes up:

GIRL 1
Try not to worry, I think it's
going to be ok- everyone has been
really nice so far.

GIRL 2
I ...I think this is great- look at
where we are.

A handful of the girls nod in agreement.

GIRL 2 (CONT'D)
One of us will be the new queen! I
think that is exciting...

AMYTIS
No one said anything about queen.

Amytis returns from the wash room.

AMYTIS (CONT'D)
This was called a beauty pageant
when they stole me from my home.

GIRL 3
What ...happened to the queen?

Everyone's eyes dart around the room.

IRDABAMA
Nobody even knows.

GIRL 2
She might've been moved somewhere?

GIRL 1
Yeah, maybe she's in another
palace...

Irdabama weeps. A discomfort grows in the room. Two more
girls go over to comfort her.

PARI
Can we maybe talk about something
else for a while?

Silence for a beat.

PARI (CONT'D)
...I think that would be a good
idea.

After a long uncomfortable silence, Nailah offers...

NAILAH
What is one thing everyone saw
today that they didn't expect to
see?

Everyone pauses and contemplates.

NAILAH (CONT'D)
I didn't expect there to be so many
water features in the palace.

There's some general agreement to the group.

PARI
I didn't know about the interior
gardens and how lush they'd be.

GIRL 3

The gardens are beautiful.

GIRL 2
I actually quite liked the food we
had for dinner.

Some more general agreements.

AMYTIS
I didn't expect to be here.

A sadness settles back in.

PARI
Maybe we should pray... in whatever
ways we all pray.

Amytis watches as everyone prepares their own type of prayer. Pari looks out the window at the night sky. Esther watches Amytis from the corner of her eye. Amytis settles in, lays down and looks up. She takes a few shallow inhales before catching a long breath in and a longer exhale. Esther sits quietly. Avoiding any obvious sign of Jewish prayer, she closes her eyes and recites inwardly.

INT. GATEHOUSE

Mordecai sits comfortably at his desk in the midst of work. He is steadily making his way through a stack of tablets- dotting T's, crossing I's. He scowls as something in the paperwork presents a problem, he looks for Bahram who is nowhere to be seen. Seeing that the crowd appears in good hands- Mordecai stands.

MORDECAI

I'll be back shortly.

His colleague waves him off. He picks up the tablet in search of a supervisor. Mordecai walks through the crowd scanning for a familiar face. He sees Haman as Haman walks to his office. Mordecai decides to give him a shot. He knocks at the open door.

MORDECAI (CONT'D)

M'Lord, I know you are the Royal Commissioner at the Gate...I'm a petition clerk here. I have a compliance issue - there's a petitioner claiming to have business directly with the king, and I can't seem to verify...

HAMAN

I don't receive clerks directly. You'll submit that through the appropriate channel. A petition clerk has a supervisor. Start there. This is not how the gate functions. You must know this. If you can't resolve a matter at your level, perhaps your level is the problem.

Mordecai takes this information in for a beat, then exits. No response. Haman is shocked. Mordecai walks away. Haman approaches his own office door.

HAMAN (CONT'D)

Excuse me...

Haman stands at his door with disgust as Mordecai doesn't turn. Walks on.

HAMAN (CONT'D)

Excuse me!...

INT. PALACE BATH — DAY

A vaulted chamber of pale limestone. Steam rises from basins cut into the floor, fed by channels that run beneath the stone — heat climbing up through the earth itself. The walls are glazed in deep blue and gold. Oil lamps set at knee height throw light upward. ATTENDANTS move at the edges of the room and disappear. What remains is stone and steam and the muffled quality of voices that will not travel far.

Memucan, Admatha, Tarshish, and MERES (another of the king's advisors) enjoy the sauna and give each other palace updates.

MERES

How does it feel to be back,
Tarshish? You must've had quite the
journey.

TARSHISH

We made it as far as Egypt and
back. Between my men and those
stationed further out, we managed
compliance from all governors. We
intercepted several carriages
leaving the area and were able to
return them. All in all, Memucan
put me to challenging work as
usual.

ADMATHA

Also like Memucan, I'm sure he
recommended the finest houses of
entertainment to visit on the way
home...

Tarshish humors Admatha with a laugh.

ADMATHA (CONT'D)

Reward for work done well, you are
dependable, Memucan.

MEMUCAN

Tarshish is our *hardest* worker. So
I'm told...

Laughs. Save for Meres.

ADMATHA

Filthy, Memucan.

TARSHISH

I appreciate the time away. Now
it's back to children, wife, these
things that ground a man.

ADMATHA

Chain a man.

MEMUCAN

Think of it as character building.

More chuckles. Meres stands up.

MERES

If you'll excuse me gentlemen, I
find I'm ready for my shower now.

He exits. Admatha chuckles. Tarshish quiet. Memucan attempts
to shift to business.

MEMUCAN

Admatha, how were the last of the
intakes, I believe they came in
today?

ADMATHA

The last three women... They are
with Hegai as we bathe. An Indian
seductress, a Grecian temptress, a
Nubian beauty...

MEMUCAN

(serious)

I'm sure it will please the king.
We will have our *first* presentation
with Xerxes this evening. He's
expecting something worthy of his
patience...

TARSHISH

I can imagine.

MEMUCAN

Most of them have been through trainings for months and the beauty rituals for weeks now. The new ones will be a bit green, but I'd say we've done a fine job.

ADMATHA

You've done a fine job. Really Memucan, you've restored the most important order to things. Things were getting...out of hand.

The men grow uncomfortable considering Vashti and shift gears.

TARSHISH

Well...to the massage rooms?

Everyone stands.

INT. WOMEN'S QUARTERS — BATH CHAMBER

The women's version of the bath. A long pale room, the air thick with myrrh. Shallow basins set into the floor hold warmed scented water. FEMALE ATTENDANTS move through the steam with oil and linen — working quietly, efficiently, hands on hair and skin. The light is soft and high. The young women receive all of this in various states of stillness.

Panning young women's faces until...Esther, her eyes are open—she is getting a pedicure. She looks across at Amytis who is getting a manicure, unhappily. Esther shifts her gaze. A few of the younger girls look really pleased with the pampering. She shifts her gaze to Nailah who also seems to be enjoying the treatment but, less so, and meets Esther's eyes knowingly. Lastly, Esther looks to Irdabama who has tears in her eyes. Esther looks back into the mirror, closes her eyes, and sits back.

INT. WOMEN'S QUARTERS— BED CHAMBER

The now 27 girls file back into their bed chamber. They each pause and look at each other... the three previously empty mats now have bags placed on them. Nailah and Pari walk to the chamber door and listen.

NAILAH

It's an orientation.

Just then the door opens. Nailah and Pari step back startled. Hegai's attendant exits followed by Hegai, then Roshna, then TWO YOUNG WOMEN and a third... AYANA.

Esther's eyes widen. Ayana scans the room, sees Esther and runs to her. The two embrace.

The other girls in the room exchange surprised glances. Not judgement. Warmth.

AYANA

Esther, I thought I'd never see you again. My family tried to outrun the search... they caught our carriage...

ESTHER

Please, tell me soon...

Esther pauses the hug, redirects Ayana's attention toward Hegai. Squeezes her hand.

Roshna's arms tense at her sides.

Hegai addresses the group.

HEGAI

The last of the 30 have arrived this evening, as you can see, I trust you will acquaint or reacquaint yourselves. We do have business this evening. In three hours time, the King has requested a procession of the contestants in the royal hall.

The young women chatter with shock. Some delight.

HEGAI (CONT'D)

This will be extraordinarily short notice for our newest arrivals. Please look to the more established residents to provide you with any of the details we were unable to cover in orientation. Again, in three hours, I will return to lead you to the royal palace floor.

Hegai pauses.

HEGAI (CONT'D)

Roshna of the Second House of Women
would like to address you.

Hegai nods to Roshna and exits quietly.

The girls look to Roshna.

Roshna fixes her gaze on the group.

ROSHNA

Young sisters of the Women's House-
You are being called upon to your
first duty. Look amongst
yourselves. This is your life,
these are your companions in it.
These women are the ones who will
take care of you when you grow
weary. Your eyes, your body, your
reality...they will be subjected to
many things. This place will take
things from you. Do right by one
another. Sisters, listen to each
other. Your words and your stories
will keep you sane, they will keep
you real, they may keep you
alive... Name your experiences to
each other and to yourselves. I
implore you... Name them. Speak
them.

Roshna looks across the room at everyone and her gaze lands
on Esther and Ayana. Ayana steps closer to Esther. Roshna
turns and exits.

The room is still as everyone takes this in. Girl 3 looks to
Nailah. Ayana looks to Esther. Esther squeezes her hand again
then looks around at Amytis and Nailah.

IRDABAMA

What do we do?

ESTHER

We get ready.

Stillness. Esther breaks the stillness by going to her chest
and pulling out the garments that have been given to her in
her time so far. Suddenly everyone does the same.

Nailah speaks to Ayana...

NAILAH

We are the same size, wear one of mine.

Nailah tosses her a spare dress. A handful of the girls are excited, preening at the mirror. The rest are preparing for duty.

The bed chamber transforms. Girls move through it in every direction at once — chests pulled from the walls to serve as surfaces, reed mats rolled back and pushed aside, the bones of the room suddenly visible.

The fabric panels — heavy dyed linen, deep blues and ochres — are being pulled back harder than usual, gathered against the columns and tied. The room opens as each one is secured, the full length of it revealed, thirty mats and thirty chests and thirty girls moving through the same space.

ATTENDANTS weave through with oil and combs, finding whoever needs them next. Someone's hair is being dressed while her own hands work at another girl's hem. Someone calls for the lamp. Someone cannot find her sash. Irdabama sits on her chest looking at her hands until Amytis who is already dressed, sits with her. Nailah moves with the efficiency of someone who has organized large spaces before. Esther works without hurry and without wasted motion. She is not performing calm, she simply is not available to panic. Ayana watches Esther and follows one beat behind.

The sound is thirty girls in a stone room— chests opening and closing, practical voices, short exchanges.

DISSOLVE TO:

INT. SECOND WOMEN'S QUARTERS — COLUMNED SITTING ROOM — NIGHT

The water feature at the center. The oil lamps low. The room as we first saw it... But the bolsters and floor pillows have been rearranged. The women are settled. Roshna and the others of the second house, the women we have seen in the margins, are gathered in a prayer circle. Roshna's lips move. Their hands held together, their eyes closed, save for...

Roshna's eyes are open. She knows what is happening on the other side of the palace.

DISSOLVE TO:

INT. WOMEN'S QUARTERS

Hegai opens the door, enters the women's quarters to find... the young women standing together, ready. He motions. They follow.

DISSOLVE TO:

SLOW MOTION-CONTINUOUS

They are led in a dance before KING XERXES (50s). He is not so much handsome as he is a man of intense gaze and engaging demeanor. He has a controlled look with emotional intensity bubbling below the surface. He is smiling but something about him looks...empty. He sits high above the girls on a platform in a throne as they are paraded before him. Wine is flowing amongst the men, instrumentalists perform at the sides of the stage.

The group of young excited girls, lean in to each other and glow with anticipation. The rest fall in line in this dance display of themselves, each paraded before the king flanked by his advisors.

Moving down the line, each girl must bow before the king. It's clear he is already a bit drunk, his eyes somewhat bleary. The men lean into each other and comment as the girls dance by.

At Esther's turn to dance by, she bows and lifts her head, she catches the king's gaze.

Several emotions flash behind his eyes, shock, fear, terror, then just as quickly, sadness, control...then...nothing... he averts his gaze to the next woman and begins to laugh...

CUT TO

Esther's face, stoic, processing what she's just seen.

BLACK

END EPISODE

CREDITS

